

Eli Wells' 37 Old-Country Home Checks That Save Money

A simple homeowner checklist for spotting small problems before they turn into big bills.

Save money. Waste less. Fix more.

Public Disclosure

Eli Wells is a fictional AI character sharing old-world home tips.

Safety Note

This guide is for simple observation and light household maintenance. It is not professional advice. Do not open dangerous systems, do not perform electrical or gas repairs, do not climb onto roofs, and do not handle mold remediation yourself. If something looks risky, document it and call someone qualified.

Use this like Eli's little notebook: one room, one check, one observation at a time.

How To Use This

Pick one room. Walk slowly. Use your eyes, your hands, a flashlight, a paper towel, and a notebook.

You are not trying to become a repairman. You are trying to notice the small signs early:

- water where it should not be
- air where it should not leak
- heat where it should not build up
- smells that keep coming back
- movement where something should be tight
- stains that return after cleaning

Eli rule:

Your house usually whispers before it yells.

The 10-Minute First Pass

Use this when you do not have time for the full checklist.

1. Check under every sink with a dry paper towel.
2. Look at window corners for moisture, swelling, or peeling paint.
3. Run your hand around doors for drafts.
4. Check the dryer lint area and make sure airflow is not blocked.
5. Look around the toilet base for staining, softness, or a wobble.
6. Check the fridge area for dust buildup and blocked airflow.
7. Look at ceilings below bathrooms for new spots.
8. Check exterior door thresholds for daylight or gaps.
9. Listen for toilets that run after the flush is finished.
10. Write down anything that came back twice.

If one of those shows up, do the deeper check below.

Doors And Drafts

1. The Dollar Bill Door Test

Close a dollar bill in the door. If it slides out with almost no resistance, the weatherstripping may be tired.

Why it matters:

- small drafts can waste heating and cooling money
- loose seals can let dust, insects, and moisture in

Safe next step:

- note which side is loose
- inspect the weatherstrip for gaps or cracking

- replace simple stick-on weatherstrip if you are comfortable

2. Daylight Under The Door

Stand inside with the lights off during the day. Look for a thin line of daylight at the bottom or corners.

Why it matters:

- daylight often means air and moisture can get in

Safe next step:

- check the door sweep
- clean the threshold
- replace the sweep if it is a simple surface-mounted type

3. Sticky Door After Rain

If a door sticks only after rain or humid weather, do not just force it.

Why it matters:

- repeated swelling can point to moisture movement

Safe next step:

- write down when it sticks
- look for peeling paint, soft trim, or water marks nearby
- call someone qualified if the frame is soft or shifting

4. Loose Strike Plate

If the latch feels sloppy, check whether the strike plate screws are loose.

Why it matters:

- loose plates make doors harder to close and can wear the frame

Safe next step:

- tighten only simple visible screws by hand
- do not force stripped screws deeper
- if the frame is cracked, document it and get help

Windows And Water

5. Window Sill Moisture That Comes Back

Wipe the sill dry. Check it again later. If moisture returns, take it seriously.

Why it matters:

- repeated moisture can damage paint, trim, and wood

Safe next step:

- photo the spot
- note weather conditions

- check whether it happens after rain, cold nights, or showers

6. Soft Paint At Window Corners

Press gently near the lower corners of the window trim.

Why it matters:

- bubbling or soft paint can mean moisture has been sitting there

Safe next step:

- do not dig into the wall
- take photos
- call someone qualified if it is soft, spreading, or smells musty

7. Dirty Track Drainage

Look at sliding window or patio door tracks. Dirt can block water paths.

Why it matters:

- blocked tracks can send water where it should not go

Safe next step:

- vacuum loose dirt
- wipe the track
- do not force tools into hidden holes

8. Curtain Stains Near One Corner

If a curtain has a stain in the same window corner, check the wall and sill behind it.

Why it matters:

- fabric can hide slow moisture signs

Safe next step:

- wash the curtain
- watch whether the stain returns
- document repeat staining

Sinks, Toilets, And Small Leaks

9. Paper Towel Under Sink Test

Wipe pipes and cabinet floor dry. Place a dry paper towel under the drain and supply lines for an hour.

Why it matters:

- tiny drips are easier to spot on paper

Safe next step:

- if the towel gets wet, photo the source
- tighten only simple hand-tight parts if you know what they are

- call someone qualified for steady leaks or hidden lines

10. Cabinet Floor Swelling

Look for raised, wavy, or dark cabinet floor material under sinks.

Why it matters:

- swelling often means water sat there before

Safe next step:

- remove stored items
- dry the area
- watch for new wetness before putting items back

11. Toilet Base Wobble

Gently place your foot near the toilet base and feel for movement. Do not rock it hard.

Why it matters:

- movement can break seals or hint at floor issues

Safe next step:

- stop using force
- check for staining around the base
- call someone qualified if it moves or leaks

12. Running Toilet Check

After a flush, wait two minutes. Listen for water continuing to run.

Why it matters:

- a running toilet can waste a surprising amount of water

Safe next step:

- note how often it happens
- simple flapper replacement may help if you are comfortable
- call someone qualified if parts are corroded or confusing

13. Slow Drain Pattern

One slow drain may be local. Several slow drains can mean a bigger issue.

Why it matters:

- patterns matter more than one-off clogs

Safe next step:

- do not pour harsh chemicals into repeated clogs
- write down which drains are slow
- call someone qualified for repeated or whole-house slow drains

Laundry And Dryer Area

14. Dryer Lint Escape

Look behind and around the dryer for lint piles.

Why it matters:

- lint buildup can reduce airflow and can be a fire risk

Safe next step:

- clean the lint screen every load
- vacuum visible loose lint around the dryer
- call someone qualified if the vent is crushed, disconnected, or hard to access

15. Dryer Takes Two Cycles

If clothes need a second cycle, do not ignore it.

Why it matters:

- poor airflow can waste energy and stress the machine

Safe next step:

- clean the lint screen
- check the visible vent path for kinks
- schedule proper vent cleaning if it keeps happening

16. Washer Hose Bulges

Look at visible washer hoses for cracking, bulging, or dampness.

Why it matters:

- tired hoses can leak suddenly

Safe next step:

- do not tug hard on old hoses
- replace simple accessible hoses if you know how and water is off
- call someone qualified if valves are stuck or corroded

17. Washer Smell That Returns

If the washer smells musty after cleaning, check the gasket, detergent drawer, and door habit.

Why it matters:

- moisture trapped in the machine can keep odor coming back

Safe next step:

- wipe accessible rubber surfaces
- leave the door cracked after use if safe in your home
- avoid mixing cleaners

Kitchen

18. Fridge Airflow Gap

Make sure the fridge is not packed tight against dust and clutter.

Why it matters:

- blocked airflow can make the fridge work harder

Safe next step:

- clear clutter around the base and rear area
- vacuum visible dust where safely reachable
- do not remove panels unless the manual says it is safe

19. Freezer Frost Pattern

Look for heavy frost buildup or one strange icy patch.

Why it matters:

- frost patterns can hint at a bad seal or airflow issue

Safe next step:

- clean the door gasket
- check whether the door closes fully
- call appliance help if frost returns quickly

20. Sink Sprayer Drip

Run the sprayer, then check under the sink with a paper towel.

Why it matters:

- sprayer hose leaks can hide inside the cabinet

Safe next step:

- document where the water appears
- stop using the sprayer if it leaks
- call someone qualified if the hose disappears into hidden areas

21. Dishwasher Edge Dampness

After a cycle, check the floor in front of the dishwasher and the cabinet sides nearby.

Why it matters:

- small dishwasher leaks can damage flooring before you notice

Safe next step:

- wipe and recheck after the next cycle
- stop using it if water appears again
- call appliance help for repeat leaks

Floors, Walls, And Ceilings

22. New Ceiling Spot

Circle the spot lightly on painter's tape, not the ceiling, and write the date.

Why it matters:

- the date helps you know whether it is growing

Safe next step:

- photograph it
- check what room sits above it
- call someone qualified if it grows, darkens, or feels damp

23. Soft Floor Near Water

Walk slowly near sinks, toilets, tubs, exterior doors, and laundry areas.

Why it matters:

- softness near water is a warning sign

Safe next step:

- do not keep stepping on soft areas
- note the location
- call someone qualified if it flexes, sags, or smells musty

24. Paint Bubble That Returns

If paint bubbles after being cleaned or dried, watch it.

Why it matters:

- repeat bubbling can point to moisture behind paint

Safe next step:

- do not scrape deeply
- photo it weekly
- call someone qualified if it spreads

25. Baseboard Gap Change

Look for baseboards pulling away from the wall in one spot.

Why it matters:

- changes can mean moisture, movement, or impact

Safe next step:

- take a photo with a coin for scale
- check again in 30 days
- get help if the gap grows

Heating, Cooling, And Airflow

26. Filter Date Check

Write the date on the edge of the filter when it is changed.

Why it matters:

- guessing leads to dirty filters staying in too long

Safe next step:

- follow your system's filter size and schedule
- do not run the system without a filter

27. Weak Room Airflow

Compare airflow from room to room with your hand.

Why it matters:

- one weak room can point to a closed vent, blocked return, or duct issue

Safe next step:

- move furniture away from vents
- check for closed registers
- call someone qualified if airflow stays weak

28. Thermostat Drift

If the room never feels like the number on the thermostat, write down the pattern.

Why it matters:

- patterns help diagnose without guessing

Safe next step:

- note time of day and weather
- replace thermostat batteries if applicable
- call HVAC help if the system short-cycles or struggles

29. Return Vent Dust Mat

Look at return vents. Heavy dust mats mean airflow may be restricted.

Why it matters:

- poor return airflow can strain the system

Safe next step:

- vacuum the grille
- replace a dirty filter
- do not open ducts or equipment panels

Exterior Ground-Level Checks

30. Water Pooling Near Foundation

After rain, look for water sitting close to the house.

Why it matters:

- water should move away from the house, not sit against it

Safe next step:

- photo the puddle
- clear obvious debris from ground-level drains
- ask a qualified pro if pooling repeats

31. Gutter Overflow From The Ground

During rain, watch from the ground for water pouring over one section.

Why it matters:

- overflow can send water down walls or near the foundation

Safe next step:

- do not climb during rain
- note the section
- schedule safe gutter cleaning if needed

32. Downspout Exit

Check whether downspouts release water too close to the house.

Why it matters:

- roof water needs a path away from the foundation

Safe next step:

- add a simple extension if appropriate
- keep discharge pointed away from walking hazards

33. Door Threshold Rot Check

Look at the bottom corners of exterior door trim.

Why it matters:

- bottom corners take weather first

Safe next step:

- press gently, do not dig
- photo soft-looking areas
- repair paint and caulk only if the material is sound

Smells, Sounds, And Repeat Warnings

34. Musty Smell That Has A Location

If a smell is strongest in one corner, cabinet, closet, or room, write it down.

Why it matters:

- location matters more than a general complaint

Safe next step:

- look for visible water signs
- improve airflow if simple and safe
- call someone qualified if the smell returns or visible growth appears

35. Buzzing, Scorch Marks, Or Heat Near Electrical Items

Do not touch or open electrical parts.

Why it matters:

- heat, buzzing, or scorch marks can be serious

Safe next step:

- stop using that outlet or device if safe to do so
- document what you noticed
- call a qualified electrician

36. Repeated Drip Sound

If you hear a drip but cannot see it, do not ignore it.

Why it matters:

- hidden water can travel before it stains

Safe next step:

- turn off noisy appliances one at a time to isolate
- check visible sink, toilet, and appliance areas
- call someone qualified if you cannot find it

37. The Same Problem Twice Rule

If the same sign comes back twice after cleaning, drying, tightening, or watching, treat it as a pattern.

Why it matters:

- repeat signs are where homeowners save money by acting early

Safe next step:

- take a photo
- write the date
- write what happened before it appeared
- call someone qualified for risky, hidden, spreading, electrical, gas, roof, or mold-related issues

Eli's Little Notebook Page

Copy this for any issue:

Date:
Room:
Spot:
What I saw:
What changed:
Weather or appliance running:
Photo taken:
Did it happen before:
Safe next step:

Final Word From Eli

Do not try to fix everything in one day. Just start noticing what your house is telling you.

Small checks. Good notes. No guessing around dangerous things.

That is how you save money, waste less, and fix more.

CTA:

Want the bigger binder when it is ready? Stay on the Eli Wells email list and I will send the first look.